

57 Ability

"Can" is a modal verb that describes what someone is able to do. It is used in different forms to describe past and present abilities.

See also:
Present simple **1**
Future with "will" **18**

57.1 "CAN / CANNOT / CAN'T"

"Can" goes between the subject and the main verb.
The verb after "can" goes in its base form.

I can ride a bicycle.



"Can" is always the same. It doesn't change with the subject.

He can play the guitar.



Base form of verb.

The negative form of "can" is "cannot" or "can't."

I {cannot can't} sing jazz songs.

The more common, short form of "cannot."



TIP

The long negative form "cannot" is always spelled as one word, not two words.

FURTHER EXAMPLES

Janet can play tennis.



He cannot climb the tree.



Bob can swim well.



They can't lift the box.



HOW TO FORM

SUBJECT

**I / You / He / She
It / We / They**

"CAN / CANNOT / CAN'T"

**can
cannot
can't**

BASE FORM

ride

OBJECT

a bicycle.